HANDOFF.md

Design & Research Handoff Frameworks

Everything you need to close a project phase cleanly — from developer-ready design annotations to stakeholder research readouts. Built for speed and clarity, not ceremony.

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1. Design Handoff to Development

Handoff Readiness Checklist

Before marking any design ready for development:

Screens & States

- [ ] All screens accounted for (including edge cases)
- [ ] Every interactive element has all states: default, hover, focus, active, disabled, error, loading, empty
- [ ] Empty states designed (no data, first-time user, error)
- [ ] Responsive breakpoints defined (mobile, tablet, desktop — as applicable)
- [ ] Dark mode / light mode covered (if required)

Components & Specs

- [ ] Components named consistently and organized in Figma
- [ ] Design tokens used (not hardcoded values) — colors, spacing, typography
- [ ] Touch targets minimum 44×44px
- [ ] Contrast ratios checked (WCAG AA minimum: 4.5:1 text, 3:1 UI components)
- [ ] Font sizes, weights, and line heights specified

Interactions & Behavior

- [ ] Interaction annotations added to complex flows
- [ ] Animation/transition specs documented (duration, easing)
- [ ] Conditional logic explained (if X then show Y)
- [ ] API dependencies flagged for engineering

Content

- [ ] All copy finalized (no Lorem Ipsum)
- [ ] Character limits noted for dynamic content fields

- [ ] Error messages and validation copy included
- [ ] Tooltips and helper text included

AI Assist — Annotation Generator

```
I have a [screen name] screen in Figma with these elements: [list elements]
Write developer handoff annotations for each element. Include:
- Behavior description (what it does)
- All states: default, hover, active, disabled, error, loading
- Any conditional logic ("only shown when X")
- Content rules (character limits, dynamic vs. static)
- Accessibility notes (ARIA labels, keyboard behavior)
Language level: Front-end developer. Precise, not verbose.
```

AI Assist — Interaction Spec Writer

```
Describe the interaction spec for this component: [describe component]
Product: [name]
Behavior: [what triggers it, what happens, what follows]
Write a concise interaction spec covering:
1. Trigger (what causes the interaction)
2. Animation (type, duration, easing — or "none")
3. State change (what visually changes)
4. Success/error handling
5. Edge cases to handle
Format for a Figma annotation or Notion doc.
```

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2. Research Handoff to Stakeholders

Research Readout Structure

Use this structure for any research findings delivery — interview synthesis, usability test results, or survey analysis.

```
1. TL;DR (3 bullets — the most important things they need to know)
2. What we did (method, participants, timeline — 3 sentences max)
3. Key findings (3–5 insights, each with evidence)
4. Design implications (insight → action table)
5. Recommended next steps (specific, owned, time-bound)
6. Appendix (transcripts, screener, raw data — for those who want to dig)
```

AI Assist — Research Readout Generator

```
Here are my research findings: [paste themes, quotes, observations]
Audience: [VP / client / product team / engineering]
Write a research readout using this structure:
1. TL;DR — 3 bullets, outcome-focused, plain language
2. What we did — 2–3 sentences (method, N, timeline)
3. Key findings — 3–5 insights with one paraphrased evidence quote each
4. Design implications — table: Insight | Design Action | Effort | Owner
5. Recommended next steps — 3 actions, each with a suggested owner
Tone: Direct and confident. No jargon. Built for a 5-minute read.
```

AI Assist — Executive Summary (60-Second Version)

```
Compress these research findings into a 60-second verbal summary for
[audience]: [paste findings]
Format:
- Opening: the single most important thing we learned
- Supporting: 2 findings that back it up
- So what: one recommended action
- Closing: what happens if we don't act
Write as spoken word — natural, not bullet-point reading.
```

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3. Design Decision Documentation

Design Rationale Template

Use when documenting why a design decision was made — for future reference, stakeholder challenges, or team onboarding.

```
Decision: [what was decided]
Date: [when]
Decision maker(s): [who]

Options considered:
1. [Option A] — [brief description + trade-off]
2. [Option B] — [brief description + trade-off]
3. [Option C, if applicable]

Evidence that informed this:
- User research: [what users said or did]
- Business requirement: [what the business needed]
- Technical constraint: [if applicable]

Decision rationale: [why this option, in 2–3 sentences]

Trade-offs acknowledged: [what we gave up or accepted]

Open questions: [anything still unresolved]

Revisit trigger: [what would cause us to reconsider this decision]
```

AI Assist — Design Rationale Writer

```
I made this design decision: [describe decision]
Alternatives I considered: [list them]
Research that informed it: [paste evidence]
Business or technical constraints: [describe]

Write a design rationale document using the standard template.
Tone: Confident but not defensive. Acknowledge trade-offs honestly.
This will be read by: [product team / client / future designers on the
project]
```

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4. Stakeholder Presentation Handoff

Presentation Structure (Design Review or Project Closeout)

Section	Content	Length
Context	What we set out to solve	1 slide
Process	How we got here (methods used)	1–2 slides
What we learned	Key insights from research	2–3 slides
What we designed	Solution walkthrough	3–5 slides
Evidence	Test results, metrics, validation	1–2 slides
Next steps	What happens now	1 slide

AI Assist — Presentation Narrative Builder

```
I need to present [project name] to [audience].
Here is what we did and found: [paste summary]
Key design decisions: [list them]
Results or validation: [test findings, metrics, or qualitative evidence]

Write a presentation narrative for [N] slides.
For each slide: title, 3-bullet content, and one visual description (chart /
screenshot / quote).
Tone: [strategic / technical / storytelling — pick one]
Audience's biggest question: [what they most want to know]
Close with a clear ask or next step.
```

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5. Figma File Organization for Handoff

File Structure Standard

```
📂 [Project Name]
  ├── 📄 Cover (project name, version, date, status)
  ├── 📄 Index (page map with descriptions)
```

```
├── 📄 Design System / Tokens (colors, type, spacing, components)
├── 📄 User Flows (high-level flow diagrams)
├── 📄 [Feature Name] — Screens
├── 📄 [Feature Name] — Screens (repeat per feature)
├── 📄 States & Edge Cases
├── 📄 Annotations & Specs
└── 📄 Archive (deprecated screens — never delete, just move here)
```

Naming Conventions

- Screens: `[Feature]/[Screen Name]/[State]` — e.g., `Onboarding/Goal Setting/Error`
- Components: `[Category]/[Name]/[Variant]` — e.g., `Button/Primary/Disabled`
- Colors: `[Role]-[Modifier]` — e.g., `brand-primary`, `feedback-error`, `neutral-300`

AI Assist — Figma Handoff Notes Generator

```
Write a Figma handoff summary note for [feature name].
What this feature does: [description]
Key screens included: [list]
Known limitations or open questions: [list]
What dev needs to know before building: [technical notes]
Accessibility requirements: [list]
Dependencies: [APIs, other features, content from other teams]
Format as a Figma cover page note — clear, scannable, under 200 words.
```

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6. Handoff Anti-Patterns

Anti-Pattern	Impact	Fix
Handing off screens without states	Dev has to guess — adds back-and-forth	Always spec all interactive states
No empty or error states	Broken production experience	Design these before handoff, not after
Hardcoded values instead of tokens	Design system debt	Use token variables in Figma from the start

Anti-Pattern	Impact	Fix
Verbal-only design rationale	No record when challenged	Document every non-obvious decision
Research findings in a slide deck no one reads	Insights get ignored	Pair the deck with a 1-page TL;DR and a verbal walkthrough
"Dev can figure out the interactions"	Wrong assumptions baked into code	Annotate anything with motion, logic, or conditional behavior